

Lesson 3: Delegating

Petra Dunn

One of the most transformational moments in my early career was when I was given my first independent assignment after completing a management training program. I got called up to the executive vice president's office and he said, "Petra, we have an assignment we'd like to offer you. We have a branch that has been losing money for well over a year. The branch manager passed away and we've seen a lot of client attrition, but we think you could develop strong relationships and turn it around. I won't sugarcoat this. It's going to be tough. And if you're not able to turn it around, no one will look negatively on you. However, if you succeed, it will be an opportunity for you to shine."

I had it turned around in six months, and it felt great.

I remember when I brought my partner on about 10 years ago. She had a great resume, good character, and a strong work ethic, but no experience in my industry. However, I knew I could teach her those skills. In our business, mistakes can be very costly, so it was no surprise that she wanted to run every decision by me. Soon, I realized I needed to teach her to take accountability for making her own decisions, but I also realized I would have to train her to carefully assess risk and have the confidence to own her own decisions.

I told her that as long as she followed the process I had taught her, I would always have her back, even if she made a mistake. She developed into a great advisor and a wonderful business partner.